It was only natural that India took the lead in hosting the One World TB Summit in Varanasi recently, because the country still has the highest burden of tuberculosis in the world. Not only do we account for almost a quarter of the total 10 million people afflicted with TB annually, we also lose more than 400,000 people a year to the disease, more than a third of the world's annual toll of 1.4 million. At the venue in Varanasi, Prime Minister Narendra Modi reiterated India's commitment to eliminate TB by 2025, five years ahead of the UN target. He also launched a TB-Mukt Panchayat Initiative to expand the ambit of India's tuberculosis elimination effort down to the last village.

However, despite the flurry of initiatives that the government has launched in recent years, experts remain sceptical of its ambition to eradicate TB entirely in India in the next two years. That is because India now has the dubious distinction of having the highest number of cases of drug-resistant tuberculosis (DR-TB), classified further as Multi-Drug-Resistant (MDR) and Extensively Drug-Resistant (XDR) TB. Both cases and deaths due to DR-TB have been growing rapidly in recent years across the country. According to the World Health Organization, India's count of 119,000 makes up more than 26 per cent of global cases of MDR-TB. "DR-TB is of growing concern in India," acknowledges C. Padmapriyadarsini, director of the ICMR-National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis (NIRT) in Chennai. She red-flags a few key drivers: irregular treatment, delay in approaching a health facility that precludes early and prompt diagnosis, and the discontinuing of medication before its prescribed course ends.

Being afflicted with TB, especially the DR variety, is a fate you wouldn't wish on your worst enemy. Debshree Lokhande, an architect from Pune, was diagnosed with TB in 2014, and immediately put on medicines. But her condition continued to worsen. Doctors found her TB resistant to three of the medicines in the standard four-drug kit. As they struggled to find a medicine that would work, Lokhande's entire left lung was destroyed within just six months, and the other infected as well. Desperate, the family approached a doctor at Hinduja Hospital in Mumbai. Lokhande was prescribed a new set of medications, including bedaquiline, which had just been approved for experimental use in 2014 and which she received on compassionate grounds. It took three years of physical struggle, grappling with severe side-effects such as loss of hearing and the financial burden of getting cochlear implants and TB drugs, for Lokhande to finally turn the corner.

BURDEN OF TB IN INDIA

2.7 million
No. of TB patients in India in 2021, a quarter of the 10 million cases worldwide

119 thousand
No. of MDR-TB cases in India, 26 per cent of global cases, per WHO

400 thousand
No. of people in India who die of TB every year, nearly a third of the global toll of 1.4 million a year